Effective Study Techniques

Many students believe that rereading their notes is the best way to prepare for an exam. Research on learning suggests otherwise. Rereading creates a feeling of familiarity, but familiarity is not the same as understanding.

A far more effective method is active recall. Instead of looking at the material, the student closes the book and tries to remember the main ideas from memory. Each attempt, even an unsuccessful one, strengthens the connections in the brain and shows exactly which topics still need attention.

Active recall works well with flashcards, practice questions and short written summaries.

Spacing and Sleep

Another powerful technique is spaced repetition. Rather than studying one subject for many hours the night before a test, the student reviews it several times over days or weeks. Short sessions separated by rest help information move into long term memory.

Sleep also plays an important role. During deep sleep the brain organizes what was learned during the day. Students who sleep well after studying usually remember more than those who stay awake all night.

Combining active recall, spaced repetition and good sleep can reduce stress and improve results.